established direct or indirect control over much of what is now Indonesia. As they expanded, they pushed out the ancient Srivijaya kingdom based in Sumatra. A naval raid on the Srivijaya capital of Palembang in 1377 finally eliminated their main rival in the region. [35]

Faced with the Javan threat, one of the Srivijaya princes, Sang Nila Utama, is said to have sought refuge in the Riau cluster of islands, just south of the Malay peninsula. One day, so the story goes, he had gone hunting on the island of Temasek where he is said to have seen a lion. So, when he built a settlement here, he named it Singapura (Sanskrit for Lion-City). This is how Singapore got its name—although the prince had almost certainly not seen a lion but a Malayan tiger. The last wild tiger of Singapore was killed in the 1930s in the neighborhood of Choa Chu Kang.

One of Sang Nila Utama's successors, Parmeswara, appears to have found Singapore untenable due to local rivalries and the continued threat of the Javans. He moved farther north and established his headquarters at Melaka (also spelled Malacca). This is what South-East Asia looked like when Admiral Zheng He arrived with the Chinese 'treasure fleet'.

Zheng He was an unlikely admiral for the Chinese fleet. He was a Muslim eunuch from land-locked Yunnan who had been brought as a boy prisoner to the Ming court and castrated. Yet, he led seven major naval expeditions between 1405 and 1433 that visited South-East Asia, India, Sri Lanka, Arabia and East Africa. The 'treasure fleets' were of an astonishing scale, with over hundred ships and tens of thousands of men. Chinese naval technology at this stage was centuries ahead of the rest of the world. In recent years, some authors have argued that Zheng He may even have visited the Americas. He certainly had the technology, but I am not convinced that he actually made the journey across the Pacific.

The naval expeditions had many objectives including trade and exploration. However, the main goal was to project Chinese power and to cement its geo-political position. The Chinese had overthrown Mongol rule just a few decades earlier, and they were very keen to establish their place in the world. If the sheer size of the fleet did not overawe the locals, Zheng